continued, ‘People get hurt in a fight. You might get hurt many times. But each wound will make you stronger. Do you get it?’

Even though it took me a while to understand what he meant, I nodded and raised my arms to hug him. He hugged me back. ‘Don’t fight back with an intention to hurt someone—fight back only to make sure they hear you . . .’

I spent the next week in bed, until my wound had healed enough for me to be able to walk. The only thing I had liked about the entire week was that I was being given full attention. All my demands were being met; there was no restriction on chocolates or chowmein. And there was no homework. But all this while I had been thinking about the things Papaji had told me. All this while, I had been devising a strategy. After a week, I went to school again. I forgot to pluck a flower for Titli Ma’am again. My mind was elsewhere. I waited through all the periods for the clock’s arms to strike recess. And as the bell rang, I ran towards the playground, limping. The ropes of the tyre swing were tied to an iron bar that rested on two iron poles on either side. There was a similar frame behind it, but without any swing on it. I took out a small ball of wool from my pocket, one I had slipped into my bag from Maa’s craft material that morning. I tied one end of the string to the right pole, stretched it taut and tied the other end to the left pole. Just beyond the string, I made a small puddle of water using my water bottle and poured into it the contents of an entire bottle of ink I’d stolen from Maa’s collection as well. Below the tyre swing, on the ground, I kept something that could lure every boy in school—marbles. After one final check, I hid myself behind a nearby guava tree. I felt a fire in my belly as I waited. The sardar boy and his two friends had started occupying the tyre swing every day, a girl in my class had told me. So I knew they would come. When they came, they saw the sparkling round marbles and bent to pick them up. That was when I took position behind them.

‘Don’t you ever push me again!’ I shouted at the top of my voice, as I stood, holding the ropes of the tyre swing that I had pulled towards me. Startled, the three of them turned to look at me. With all the force I had, I swung the tyre towards them. It pushed the three of them back, and as they